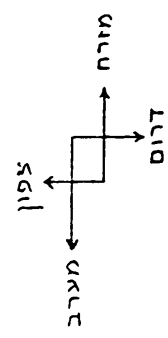


SIDRA OF THE WEEK: במדבר

1. This week's Sidra is the first in the fourth *Sefer* of the Five Books of the Torah. It treats of the counting of the Jewish People (and thereby gives it its name "*Chumash haPekkuddim*" or "Numbers"); how we were encamped during our time in the Wilderness of Sinai on our way out from Egypt to Eretz Yisroel; the order in which we broke camp and travelled; some of the duties of the different houses of the Tribe of Levi; and the names of those in charge.
2. In the same way as a king newly enthroned wishes to get to know his subjects so too before HaShem came to dwell amongst us in the recently completed Sanctuary, HaShem commanded Mosheh to take a count of His People. By ordering the counting of the People of Israel — every man aged twenty years or more was to be included — HaShem showed that each man standing at the head of his household, prepared to place himself with his family within the ranks of HaShem's People, under the rule of HaShem and His Torah, is precious to Him.
3. The method of counting, too, is indicative of the importance of each person: The people were not to be counted directly, for this could imply that each is no more than a number. Instead, the Torah commands that each man gives a token (a half-Shekel) and these tokens are counted. The silver thus collected goes towards the upkeep of the Mishkan HaShem, and thus symbolizes how the Jewish People in its totality becomes the Abode of the Divine Presence.
4. The Tribe of Levi, however, is not included in the general count: as befits their special status as "the Legion of the King" they are counted separately. Similarly, whereas the Tribes of Israel were encamped round the Mishkan at a distance, the Levites, the guardians of the Sanctuary, encamped closer to the Mishkan. The position of each Tribe's camp is given in this week's Sidra (see PLAN below) and the procedure of breaking camp and travelling is also described.
5. As reward for their unbroken loyalty to Him, HaShem commands the Levites to be the assistants to the Kohanim instead of the firstborns of the Children of Israel, and their induction into their Divine Service and their various duties are described.

For the explanation of the Haftarah of Sidra במדבר please go to HAFTORAHS.

תמונה



NOT DRAWN TO SCALE

12 מיל = approximately 9 miles.

In the corners of the Camp:

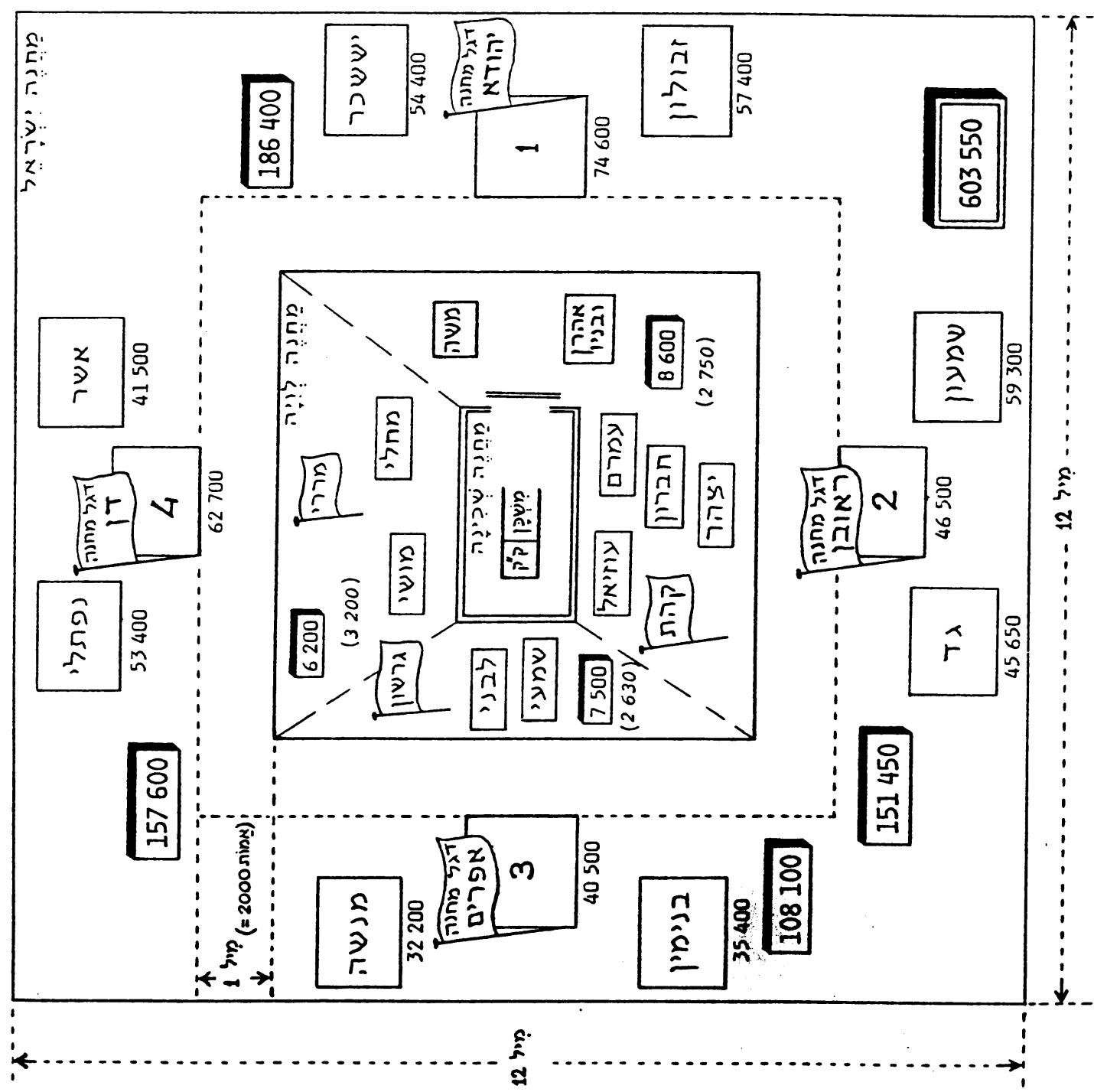
sheep, cattle, livestock, etc.

Levi'im: Numbers in boxes are of males aged between one month and fifty years; numbers in brackets are of males over thirty years of age. Totals: 22 000 and 8 580 respectively. [במדבר ג' לט: ד' מה']

The Mishkan with the whole of

מחנה לוזה and מחנה שכינה travelled after ראוהבן and before אפרים.

PLAN OF THE CAMP
 OF THE
 IN THE WILDERNESS
 (פרשת במדבר ופרשת נשא)



במדבר : SIDRA OF THE WEEK

וַיֵּסַע אֹהֶל מוֹעֵד מִחֻנֵּה הַלְוִיִּם בְּתוֹךְ הַמַּחֲנֹת כַּאֲשֶׁר יֶחֱנוּ בֵּין יָסְעוּ ...

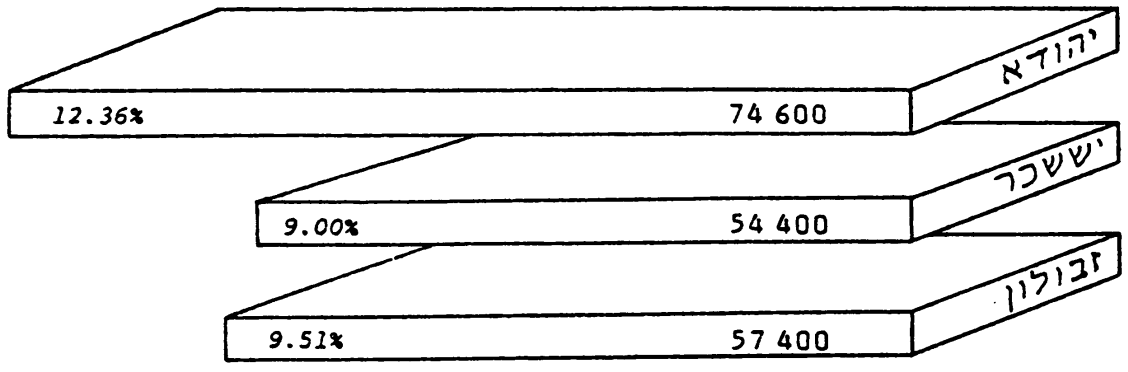
[במדבר, ב' : י"ז]

The Ohel Mo'ed [and] the Camp of the Levi'im travelled in the midst of the camps [of the Tribes] — as they encamped, so they travelled ...

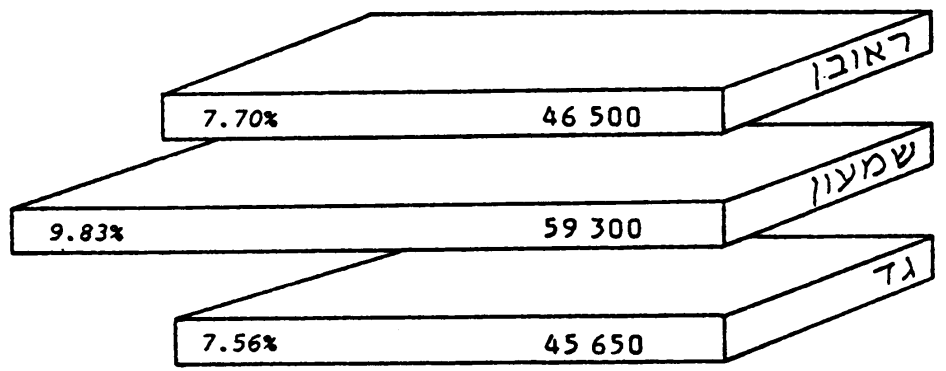
[Bemidbor, 2 : 17]

The first of the camps to travel was the camp comprising the Tribes of Yehuda, Yissochor and Zevulun, travelling under the flag of the leading Tribe, Yehuda. After them, the boards and the hangings and the curtains and the screens, etc., that all together formed the actual structure of the Mishkan, travelled. The great boards (which were the walls — there were 48 such boards) and the five pillars of the Mishkan (on which was hung the screen which formed the entrance of the Mishkan) and the columns of the Court around the Mishkan (there were 56 such columns) and the copper pegs and the ropes for the linen hangings which were hung from the columns and together formed the Court of the Mishkan, with the sockets for those boards, pillars and columns (there were some 160 sockets altogether — there were 96 silver sockets, each weighing one talent (approximately 68 kg) under the 48 boards of the Mishkan, two sockets for each board, and the other sockets, one for each pillar or column, were of copper) and the bolts for the walls of the Mishkan, etc., were transported by the Merorites of the Tribe of Levi. The coverings and the curtains and the entrance screen of the Mishkan and the entrance screen to the Court of the Mishkan, with their pegs and cords, etc., were transported by the Gershonites of the Tribe of Levi. The Gershonites and Merorites went ahead of the Kehosites and they would set up the Mishkan in the new location and so the Kehosites would find the Mishkan ready for the sacred furniture which they, the Kehostes, carried. After the Merorites and the Gershonites, the next camp to travel was the camp comprised of the Tribes of Reuven, Shimon and Gad, travelling under the flag of Reuven. After this second camp had moved off, the Kehosites travelled, as just said, carrying the Holy Ark and the other sacred furniture. This included the Table, the Menorah, the Golden Altar for the offerings of the incense, the Great Copper Altar, the Copper Wash Basin and its Copper Stand and also the Porochess, that is, the screen which separated between the Holy and the Holy of Holies. All this was not loaded on to any wagons but was carried on the shoulders of the Kehosites of the Tribe of Levi. The third camp to travel comprised the Tribes of Efrayyim, Menashe and Binyomin, travelling under the flag of Efrayyim, and they travelled immediately after the Kehosites. Finally, the camp of the Tribe of Dan, together with the Tribes of Osher and Naftoli, travelling under the flag of the Tribe of Dan, took up the rear. (Within this camp, therefore, there was a place for the claim and return of lost property.) Thus, figuratively as well as in fact, the *מַחֲנֶה שְׂכִינָה* and the *מַחֲנֶה לְוִיָּה* travelled within the camps of the Tribes of Israel — “as they encamped, so they travelled.”

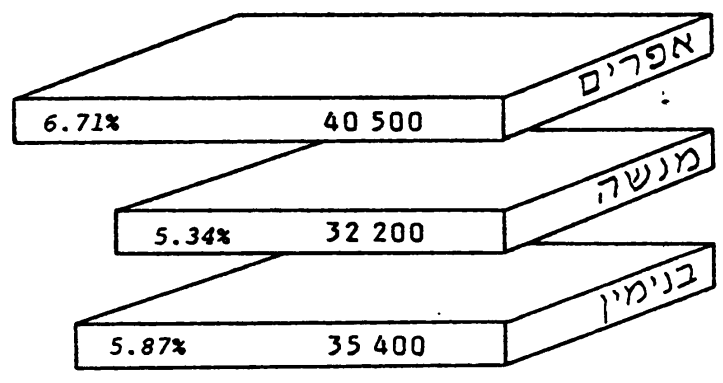
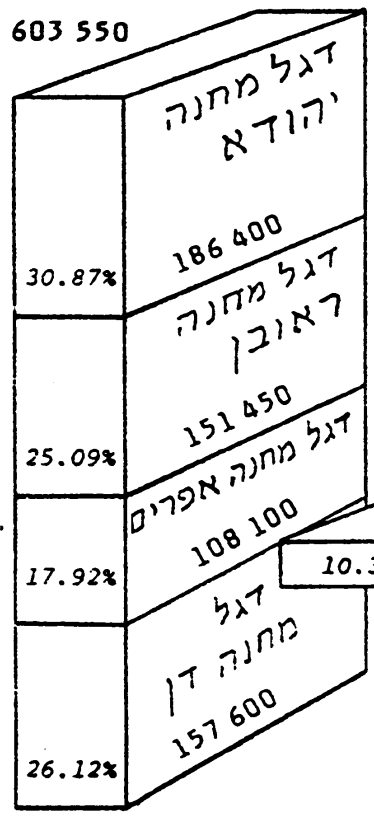
אלה הפקודים אשר פקד משה ואהרן ונשיאי ישראל
[במדבר א': מד]



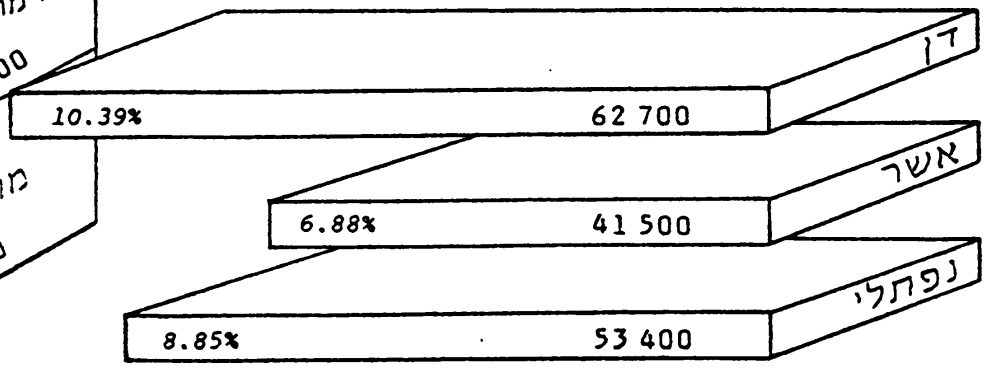
1



2



3



4